TWO ENGLISH MUGS PODCAST

Train Your Ears to Understand Real English

Episode 26 · Full Transcription

Emma & Josh

B1 Intermediate

EMMA: So, uh, when you hear people talk fast in English, what does it actually sound like to you?

JOSH: Oh man, like a giant wall of noise. Honestly, I used to think native speakers were just making sounds up.

EMMA: Like just random noises?

JOSH: Yeah, exactly. Like a drum solo where the drummer has just completely lost his mind.

EMMA: Drum solo?

JOSH: Yeah, because there were no spaces, just zero spaces between the words.

EMMA: Right. One long running sound.

JOSH: Literally, it felt like they wanted to confuse me on purpose.

EMMA: Well, I used to think people were actually talking while breathing in, not out.

JOSH: Wait, really?

EMMA: Yeah.

JOSH: Breathing in?

EMMA: Yeah. It sounded so fast and tight. I thought surely they are just pulling air in to make that sound.

JOSH: That is so funny.

EMMA: But yeah, today we are actually talking about how to train your ears to catch those spaces.

JOSH: Train your ears. I don't know. That sounds like a totally lazy idea.

EMMA: A lazy idea?

JOSH: Yeah. Like just hear better. Come on. That is impossible.

EMMA: It is not a lazy idea at all. There is a real step-by-step way to actually do it.

JOSH: Well, I will believe it when I see it or, uh, hear it.

EMMA: Fair enough. So let's get right into it. Hello and welcome to Two English Mugs, where we learn English through real everyday conversations. I'm Emma.

JOSH: And I'm Josh.

EMMA: So today we are looking at exactly why fast English sounds like pure noise and how to fix it.

JOSH: Right. And just to be clear for everyone, this is a chat for people right in the middle,

EMMA: meaning B1 level.

JOSH: Exactly. Not baby words, but, you know, not super advanced hard talk either.

EMMA: Right. We keep it nice and simple.

JOSH: And we explain any new words as we go. Oh, and the free PDF transcript is down in the description.

EMMA: Perfect. So we are going to cover 3 main points today, but, um, I am actually keeping the third one a secret for later.

JOSH: Oh wow, keeping secrets already?

EMMA: You have to stick around for the best part.

JOSH: I see how it is.

EMMA: So first up, why does it actually sound like noise?

JOSH: Uh, because native speakers drink way too much coffee and just talk too fast.

EMMA: I mean, true, but it is a bit more physical than that.

JOSH: Physical? How?

EMMA: The words actually crash into each other.

JOSH: Crash? Like, like cars on a road?

EMMA: Yes. Think of words like those bumper cars at a funfair.

JOSH: Oh, I love bumper cars.

EMMA: Right? So in a book, words sit super neatly in a row.

JOSH: Like they're safely parked.

EMMA: Exactly. Each car has its own clear, safe space.

JOSH: Like, I am going to the shop.

EMMA: Right. But human mouths are naturally very lazy.

JOSH: We really are.

EMMA: We want to say things with zero effort.

JOSH: Like taking the absolute easiest path.

EMMA: Exactly. So the mouth takes a shortcut. The cars speed up and they just slam together.

JOSH: And when they crash, parts just fly off.

EMMA: Yes. Words blend together, parts break off entirely, and totally new sounds pop right out of the crash.

JOSH: That makes a lot of sense, actually. The mouth wants to save energy so the jaw does not get tired out.

EMMA: Right. And if you only read books, your brain is just looking for that neat row of safe cars.

JOSH: But your ear gets the messy crash instead.

EMMA: Yes. So your brain waits to hear going to, but the person actually said gonna.

JOSH: And my brain just says, wait, what is a gonna? Is that like a type of food?

EMMA: Exactly. It does not match the book at all. Plus, There are fully new sounds you have to deal with.

JOSH: You mean sounds that might not even exist in my first language?

EMMA: Yes. This is a very big one, like the th sound.

JOSH: Oh man, I know this one. The th sound in think or this?

EMMA: Exactly. Your tongue has to sit right between your teeth.

JOSH: I hated that sound so much when I was learning.

EMMA: Really? Why?

JOSH: It just feels so silly to stick your tongue out while you talk.

EMMA: Many people feel exactly that way. But if your home language does not have it—

JOSH: My brain basically has no box to put it in.

EMMA: Right. It literally just skips the sound entirely, or it swaps it for an S or an F just to be safe.

JOSH: Because the brain is really trying to be helpful. It hears a strange noise and just takes a wild guess.

EMMA: Yeah. I hear people say sink instead of think all the time.

JOSH: Oh yeah. A very classic mix-up. And it totally proves why the brain gets so tired.

EMMA: Right. It is working extra hard to build those brand new boxes for weird sounds.

JOSH: Okay, so we have words crashing, sounds dropping, and vowels completely changing shape.

EMMA: That is point 1.

JOSH: Got it. Which brings us to point 2, the actual crashes. What do they sound like in real life?

EMMA: This is the fun part, honestly, the sound tricks. People use glued words every single day.

JOSH: Glued words? You mean like sticky words just stuck together?

EMMA: Yes. 2 or 3 words glued together to make one fast word.

JOSH: Okay, give me an example of that.

EMMA: Like, want to becomes wanna.

JOSH: Right. I wanna go home.

EMMA: Exactly. And have to turns into hafta, like, I hafta go.

JOSH: Wait, so the heavy V sound in have Actually turns into an F sound.

EMMA: Yes, because an F is way softer and much easier to say fast. Hafta.

JOSH: That is wild.

EMMA: But if you say I have to go with hard stops, you sound like a strict teacher

JOSH: or a robot.

EMMA: Beep boop. I have to go now.

JOSH: Exactly. Hafta is the normal warm way we talk to our friends.

EMMA: Yeah. It really is. What about got to?

JOSH: Oh, that becomes gotta.

EMMA: Yeah.

JOSH: As in, I gotta find my keys before we leave.

EMMA: Perfect. And there are plenty of smaller ones too. Kind of becomes kinda.

JOSH: I am kinda hungry right now.

EMMA: Right. Sort of becomes sorta. A lot of becomes lotta.

JOSH: That is a lot of food for one person.

EMMA: And my absolute top pick, don't know, melts all the way down to Dunno.

JOSH: Dunno. Wow, you barely even open your lips for that one.

EMMA: You really don't. You just make a small lazy sound deep in your throat. I dunno.

JOSH: The jaw does literally no work at all.

EMMA: None. But honestly, the best glued word is what happens to what are you.

JOSH: Oh, whatcha. Like, whatcha doing today?

EMMA: Yes. And I really have to ask, did you ever get totally confused by that specific one?

JOSH: Okay, yes. True story. Actually, I was watching a film years ago.

EMMA: Oh no, what happened? Prepare this.

JOSH: A guy walked into the room and said, "Hey Watcha, how are you?"

EMMA: Wait, really?

JOSH: Yes. I thought Watcha was his friend's actual name.

EMMA: You thought he was greeting a guy named Watcha?

JOSH: Yes. Hello, my good friend Watcha. I mean, how was I supposed to know?

EMMA: That is amazing, and honestly, it makes total sense why you thought that.

JOSH: Nobody ever teaches you that what are you squishes into a strange name like whatcha.

EMMA: They really don't. It sounds absolutely nothing like the start words.

JOSH: But that is just how people talk.

EMMA: We really do glue it all together.

JOSH: So do letters ever just vanish totally?

EMMA: All the time. The biggest trick is the lost H.

JOSH: The lost H. Where does it go? Does it just run away?

EMMA: It just drops off. When people talk fast, they simply do not push the air out for the heavy H.

JOSH: So if I want to say, tell him to come over.

EMMA: You would actually say, tell 'em to come over. The H is fully gone.

JOSH: Tell 'em. Wow, that is so incredibly lazy.

EMMA: It is just very fast. What did he do becomes, what did he do.

JOSH: It feels like the words are dropping heavy weight just so they can run faster.

EMMA: That is a really great picture, actually. Next trick, the soft T, or the flap T.

JOSH: Flap T. That sounds like a bird flying around.

EMMA: It is all about the tongue. In American English especially, the T often changes into a very soft

JOSH: Okay, give me a clear example of that one.

EMMA: The word water. A British person might hit that T very hard. Water.

JOSH: Very crisp. Very polite.

EMMA: Exactly. But an American—

JOSH: They say water.

EMMA: Yes. The tongue does not stop to make a sharp, hard T.

JOSH: It just flaps against the top of the mouth.

EMMA: Exactly. Just a quick, lazy flap. It bounces right off. Water.

JOSH: Oh, so the word little becomes little.

EMMA: Yes! And city becomes city.

JOSH: Man, this is exactly why my brain gets so lost. The printed letters are basically lying to me.

EMMA: The letters are just a map, really. The real-life sound is much, much softer.

JOSH: Are there any other tricks? Because my brain is already getting pretty full.

EMMA: Just one more for now. The stressed beat. The music of the word.

JOSH: Right. English is a very bouncy language. Lots of up and down.

EMMA: It is. Every big word has one strong beat, one part that is louder and held longer.

JOSH: Like the word photograph. The heavy beat is right at the start. Pho-to-graph.

EMMA: Exactly. But watch what happens if we change the word just a bit to photography.

JOSH: No, it is not pho-to-graphy.

EMMA: No, the strong beat totally moves to the middle. It becomes photography.

JOSH: Wow. The exact same root word, but the music totally changes.

EMMA: And if you put the heavy beat in the wrong spot, native speakers will just stare at you.

JOSH: Even if I say all the actual letters perfectly right?

EMMA: Even then. The brain really needs that musical beat to unlock the word.

JOSH: English is so unfair sometimes.

EMMA: It just takes practice, I promise.

JOSH: All right, before we talk about how to actually fix all this noise, let's take a quick pause.

EMMA: Yeah, good idea.

JOSH: I need a pause. My head is spinning from all these rules.

EMMA: Well, if you are listening at home, I want you to finish this sentence in the comments below.

JOSH: Okay, what is the sentence they have to finish?

EMMA: When someone speaks English too fast, My brain feels like.

JOSH: Ooh, I like that. My brain feels like an old computer crashing.

EMMA: Exactly. Let us know how it feels for you in the comments.

JOSH: Okay, so time for the third point—the big secret you held back at the start.

EMMA: Finally,

JOSH: how do we actually train our ears? I am totally ready for the magic trick.

EMMA: Well, there are no magic tricks here; just a really smart routine. First step. It is about how you watch TV.

JOSH: Oh, I turn on the words at the bottom, the subtitles. That is how I always watch.

EMMA: Yes, everyone does. But there is a smart way to use them.

JOSH: Wait, what is the wrong way?

EMMA: Using subtitles in your home language.

JOSH: But that helps me know what is happening in the story.

EMMA: It does, but your brain is lazy. It just reads your home language.

JOSH: So it stops listening to the English audio entirely?

EMMA: Yes. You think you are training your ears, but you are really only training your eyes.

JOSH: Oh, wow. So I'm basically tricking myself.

EMMA: Exactly. So here's the SMART cycle. Step 1, watch a short video with all subtitles completely off.

JOSH: That sounds very scary. I will miss all of it.

EMMA: That is okay. Let it be messy. Just listen to the noise. Then step 2.

JOSH: What is step 2?

EMMA: Turn on the English subtitles.

JOSH: So now I am matching the weird noise To the real English word.

EMMA: Yes. Your eyes and ears finally work together. Then step 3, turn them off again.

JOSH: And rewatch it one more time.

EMMA: Yes. By the third time, your brain actually knows what the messy sounds mean without looking.

JOSH: Oh, I see. So you are building the bridge in your mind.

EMMA: Exactly.

JOSH: That is actually really clever. But what if it is still way too fast?

EMMA: If it is too fast, use the speed button.

JOSH: You mean slow the video or podcast down?

EMMA: Yes. Drop it down to 0.75 speed.

JOSH: I don't know. That feels a little bit like cheating.

EMMA: It is not cheating at all. It slows the bumper cars down so you can actually see the crash.

JOSH: Ah, that makes a lot of sense. And once I can hear it, I can speed it back up.

EMMA: Right. But here is the hard part of the plan. You must listen to the exact same clip again.

JOSH: Over and over? That sounds so boring. I want to hear new stories.

EMMA: I know it sounds super dull, but think about how you learn a brand new song.

JOSH: Okay, so the first time I just hear the beat and maybe the guitar.

EMMA: Right. The second time, maybe you catch a few lines of the chorus.

JOSH: And by the 10th time, I am singing the whole song loudly in the shower.

EMMA: Yes, language is exactly the same process.

JOSH: So the first time I listen, I just hear the big nouns and verbs.

EMMA: The second time, you start to hear the smaller glued words.

JOSH: And by the fifth time, I can actually hear the dropped H and the lazy flap T.

EMMA: Exactly. You pull the layers apart piece by piece until it is totally clear.

JOSH: Okay, I can do that. What is next?

EMMA: Now, there is one more active trick. It is called shadowing.

JOSH: Shadowing? Wait, so I am just supposed to talk over someone while they speak?

EMMA: Pretty much. You act like an echo. You repeat what they say out loud.

JOSH: Does that not just create way more noise in my head? How does talking help my ears?

EMMA: Because your mouth and your ears are tightly linked. If you force your mouth to make the fast sounds—

JOSH: Then my brain learns how the sounds actually feel physically.

EMMA: Exactly. When you feel the bumpy rhythm in your own mouth, Your ears get much better at catching it.

JOSH: Okay. I will try being an echo. But what kind of audio should I pick for this?

EMMA: You want to use the 70 to 80% rule.

JOSH: What is that rule?

EMMA: It means you should catch about 70 to 80% of the audio right from the start.

JOSH: So it is not too easy and it is not too hard.

EMMA: Exactly. If you know every single word, your brain is not stretching at all.

JOSH: But if I know nothing, it is just stressful, angry noise.

EMMA: Right. You want that middle sweet spot. Like you can follow the main story, but your brain still works.

JOSH: That sounds like a really solid plan.

EMMA: And when you listen closely, you will start hearing everyday filler phrases.

JOSH: The little extra words people say to fill the quiet gaps.

EMMA: Yes. They are the glue of normal chats, like the phrase, by the way.

JOSH: Right. By the way, I saw your friend today. It just adds a new random fact.

EMMA: Or the phrase, you know what I mean?

JOSH: That is just checking if you are still paying attention. It is so cold outside. You know what I mean?

EMMA: And then there's, I mean.

JOSH: We say this one nonstop in English. I mean, the food was okay. It's just a soft pause to think.

EMMA: And the 2 biggest ones.

JOSH: Like and literally.

EMMA: Oh yeah.

JOSH: I was like, wow.

EMMA: People use literally even when it is totally not true. I am literally dying of hunger right now.

JOSH: You are not dying. You just really want a big sandwich.

EMMA: Exactly. It is just used for heavy drama.

JOSH: Well, let's actually show how all of this sounds in real life. Let's do a fast scene at a cafe.

EMMA: Oh, I love a cafe scene.

JOSH: Okay, so we are standing at the till to pay. I am waiting and you run in late. Ready?

EMMA: I am ready. Let's act it out.

JOSH: Hey, I am so glad you could make it. I wasn't sure if you'd come.

EMMA: Yeah, sorry I'm a little late. The traffic was crazy today. I don't know what was going on.

JOSH: No worries at all. What you gonna have?

EMMA: I'm thinking a latte. A big one. I'm kind of tired today.

JOSH: Yeah, me too. I think I'm gonna get a black coffee. Something strong.

EMMA: Ooh, black coffee. That is brave. I can't drink it without milk. It is too bitter.

JOSH: I sort of got used to it over time.

EMMA: Maybe I will get a cappuccino instead. The coffee here is really good, and it's not too pricey.

JOSH: Same. Okay, let's go order.

EMMA: Deal.

JOSH: Okay, let's freeze it there and break that down. That was very normal, fast English.

EMMA: The first thing was the phrase make it. You said, glad you could make it.

JOSH: Right. We were not building a house or creating something. Make it just means to arrive.

EMMA: And then I said dunno instead of don't know. I was very lazy.

JOSH: And I asked whatcha gonna have instead of what are you going to have?

EMMA: That is 3 whole words squished into one. Whatcha, my old best friend.

JOSH: Yes, your good buddy whatcha. We also hit kinda. And sorta.

EMMA: It is wild how many glued words fit into a tiny short chat about coffee.

JOSH: It really is. It changes the whole shape of how the talk sounds.

EMMA: Okay, that brings us perfectly to our vocab unwind. Let's review 5 keywords from today.

JOSH: I am ready. Give me the new words.

EMMA: Word number 1 is pricey. Repeat after me. Pricey.

JOSH: Pricey.

EMMA: Word number 1 is an informal, quick way to say something costs a lot of money.

JOSH: I really want to buy those new running shoes, but they are way too pricey for me.

EMMA: Spot on. Word number 2 is hooked. Repeat after me. Hooked.

JOSH: Hooked.

EMMA: Word number 2 is when you are caught by something and can't stop, like a good book.

JOSH: I watched just one episode of that space show, and now I am totally hooked.

EMMA: Perfect. Word number 3 is serendipity. Repeat after me. Serendipity.

JOSH: Serendipity. That was a very long one.

EMMA: Word number 3 is finding something wonderful by accident when you are not looking for it.

JOSH: I got lost on my walk and found a beautiful secret garden. It was pure serendipity.

EMMA: Such a beautiful word. Word number 4 is consistent. Repeat after me. Consistent.

JOSH: Consistent.

EMMA: Word number 4 is doing the same thing in a steady way, day after day.

JOSH: If you want to get strong at the gym, you have to be consistent. Can't just go once.

EMMA: Exactly right. And the last one, word number 5 is deal. Repeat after me. Deal.

JOSH: Deal.

EMMA: Word number 5 is a very fast way to agree to a plan with a friend.

JOSH: You buy the concert tickets, and I will buy the snacks. Deal.

EMMA: Great. So our 5 words were pricey, hooked, serendipity, consistent, and deal.

JOSH: Those are very handy words for normal everyday life.

EMMA: All right, let's wrap this up. We promised 3 big points today. First, we looked at why fast English sounds like noise. The mouth gets lazy, words crash like bumper cars, and letters drop.

JOSH: Second, we looked at sound tricks. Glued words like gonna and whatcha, plus the lost H and the lazy flap T.

EMMA: And third, we gave you the training plan. The smart way to use subtitles, slow the speed down, and shadow like an echo.

JOSH: And play the exact same audio many times until you catch the hidden layers.

EMMA: If you liked this episode, please hit the like button and subscribe. Now, thank you all so much for hanging out with us and doing the hard work.

JOSH: Take care of your family, and we invite you back for next week's episode.

EMMA: Keep listening. Bye for now.

Vocab Unwind

5 key words and phrases from this episode

#	WORD	MEANING	ANALOGY	EXAMPLE
1	**pricey**	An informal, quick way to say something costs a lot of money.	Looking at the price tag, then putting the shoes back on the shelf.	*I really want to buy those new running shoes, but they are way too pricey for me.*
2	**hooked**	When you are caught by something and can't stop, like a good book.	Like a good book you cannot put down at midnight.	*I watched just one episode of that space show, and now I am totally hooked.*
3	**serendipity**	Finding something wonderful by accident when you are not looking for it.	Taking a wrong turn and finding a secret garden.	*I got lost on my walk and found a beautiful secret garden. It was pure serendipity.*
4	**consistent**	Doing the same thing in a steady way, day after day.	A tap dripping every second, not a wave that comes once.	*If you want to get strong at the gym, you have to be consistent. Can't just go once.*
5	**deal**	A very fast way to agree to a plan with a friend.	Shaking hands in one word.	*You buy the concert tickets, and I will buy the snacks. Deal.*